is to document the increasing erosion of India's secular fabric which she describes in the context of the Babri Masjid demolition. She has been witness to the deepening communal and political faultlines across India in her years of reporting. But perhaps the signal contribution of the book is to provide witness to the decline of the standards of journalism across the country. The devil-may-care ground reporting when journalists spoke truth to power is a thing of the past. Equally important was its neutrality as compared to the situation today where political pressures and misinformation rule the roost.

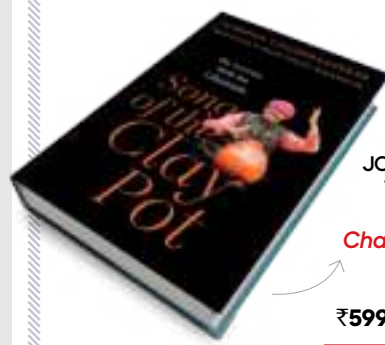
Journalists' accounts have been called the "first draft of history". On that score this is a major contribution, covering as it does some of the most significant phases of modern Indian history. Baweja's narrative is authoritative, engaging and highlights the essential role of independent, courageous journalism in a democracy. ■

—Manoj Joshi

CALL OF CLAY

Song of the Clay Pot seamlessly blends memoir with music history

IT ALL BEGAN WITH A RECURRING. RESTLESS DREAM. On a warm March night in 2008, Sumana Chandrashekar woke up to find her fingers moving on her belly, with the sounds of the ghatam—the clay pot used as a percussion instrument in Carnatic music—ringing in her ears. The dream kept pulling her back in, until Chandrashekar, an accomplished Carnatic vocalist, realised that it was a calling she couldn't ignore.



SONG OF THE CLAY PLOT: MY JOURNEY WITH THE GHATAM
by Sumana Chandrashekar
SPEAKING TIGER
₹599; 276 pages

In *Song of the Clay Pot*, this summons is the starting point for an exploration of this ancient instrument, and the histories—cultural, political, personal—that live inside its resonant body. The ghatam becomes both subject and lens through which Chandrashekar interrogates ideas about who gets to make music, who gets to be seen, and how sound itself can carry the weight of social hierarchies. Blending memoir, ethnography and feminist critique, the book traces the ghatam's journey from the potter's wheel to the biggest stages. Chandrashekar speaks to families that have made ghatams for centuries, and laments the loss of the ponds and lakes that are the source of its clay.

Some of the book's most compelling insights come from her dissections of the hierarchies—of gender, caste and class—that inform Indian classical music and the ghatam's place in it. As one of the few prominent women to play the instrument, she knows first-hand how patriarchal tradition has policed women and femininity in these spaces. She writes about these experiences not with bitterness, but with a subversive clarity.

What makes *Song of the Clay Pot* such a singular work is its refusal to separate music from material reality. Chandrashekar writes with the precision of a performer who knows the value of restraint. The result is a rare kind of memoir—one that listens as intently as it speaks, letting the clay hum its own truth. ■

—Bhanuj Kappal

item of lingerie; the body of an academic from Jharkhand, accused of sexual harassment by a student, is found in Avtar's hotel: the offending weapon used in the murder—a miniature of the Qutub Minar. Meanwhile, an elderly Pakistani pilgrim-tourist living in the hotel goes missing, drawing in the local cops and the Indian secret service.

Like an old Irish race horse, the story moves at a gentle gallop, guaranteed to raise a chuckle at every bend: "Mass-goers in Ireland used to compare notes and pick services depending on which priest would have you in and out of Mass in the shortest time."

There are some wonderful animal metaphors: Sister Agatha hopes that a sub-inspector sees her less as a tiger and more like a honey badger, an unglamorous but fierce animal. A doctor has the look of a hedgehog: "Small and hunched, silver hair springing up and back from his forehead...." Avtar, observing the close-set buildings from his hotel rooftop: "Baby birds still in the nest, beaks up and open, calling to be fed." But then follows a cliché about old Delhi: "Busy, pulsating with life...goods stacked alluringly." The novel makes for a snug winter read, although it leaves one mystery unsolved. Why does Sister Agatha habitually buy a pack of cigarettes, smoke one and give the packet away; being an old India hand, she surely knows that she can buy cigarettes loose. ■

THE STORY MOVES AT A GENTLE GALLOP, GUARANTEED TO RAISE A CHUCKLE AT EVERY BEND

—Palash Krishna Mehrotra